

Grant Proposal: Hull Waterfront Cleanup and Litter Prevention Initiative



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Written on behalf of: S.O.S. Hull (Save Our Space)

Authored by: Richard Bertone

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Richard Bertone
150 Hicks Way
Amherst MA, 01003-9274

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Massachusetts Environmental Trust
100 Cambridge Street, 10th Floor
Boston, MA 02114

Dear Members of the Board,

Please accept this proposal for consideration for funding from the Massachusetts Environmental Trust on behalf of S.O.S. Hull (Save Our Space), a volunteer-driven community organization dedicated to preserving and enhancing public land and coastal resources in Hull, Massachusetts. This proposal seeks grant support for the Hull Waterfront Cleanup and Litter Prevention Initiative, a coordinated program of volunteer-based shoreline cleanups and long-term litter prevention strategies designed to protect Hull's coastal ecosystems, improve water quality, and foster sustained community stewardship.

Hull's extensive public waterfront is among its most valuable assets, serving residents, visitors, and wildlife alike. However, seasonal tourism, storm events, and limited waste infrastructure contribute to persistent litter accumulation along beaches, seawalls, and tidal zones. Single-use plastics, food packaging, and other debris threaten marine life, degrade water quality, and undermine the town's environmental and economic well-being. While informal volunteer efforts exist, Hull currently lacks a structured, recurring cleanup program paired with preventive education and infrastructure.

This proposal outlines a feasible, community-centered initiative that aligns closely with the Massachusetts Environmental Trust's mission to protect aquatic resources and engage residents in environmental stewardship. Through partnership with S.O.S. Hull, local volunteers, and waterfront businesses, the project will organize recurring cleanup events, install targeted litter-prevention tools, and educate residents and visitors about responsible coastal use. Importantly, the project is designed to be scalable and replicable in other small coastal communities across Massachusetts.

We respectfully request funding in the amount of **\$40,000** to support a one-year pilot implementation of this initiative. Grant funds will be used to purchase cleanup and safety equipment, support educational materials, and coordinate volunteer efforts. With the support of the MET, this project will produce measurable environmental improvements while strengthening Hull's culture of community-led conservation.

Thank you for your time and consideration. We appreciate the Massachusetts Environmental Trust's longstanding commitment to safeguarding the town and think this project would be a great fit for your sponsorship.

Sincerely,

Richard Bertone

On behalf of S.O.S. Hull (Save Our Space)

Statement of the Problem

Massachusetts' coastal communities face increasing environmental pressure, particularly from human activity and climate change. Marine litter has become one of the most visible and persistent manifestations of this pressure, particularly in small coastal towns whose shorelines are heavily used but modestly resourced. Hull, a small town on the Massachusetts South Shore, is particularly vulnerable due to its extensive shoreline, high seasonal tourism, and exposure to coastal storms. Beaches and waterfront walkways that define Hull's identity are increasingly affected by litter accumulation, especially during summer months and following storm events.

Hull's beaches, seawalls, and waterfront walkways are central to the town's identity and daily life. They serve not only as recreational spaces for residents and visitors, but also as habitats for birds, shellfish, and other marine and coastal organisms. During peak summer months and in the aftermath of storm events, these areas experience a marked increase in debris, notably single-use plastics or food containers, and fishing-related waste. Marine debris is not solely an aesthetic concern. Plastics and other waste pose serious risks to marine and coastal wildlife through ingestion and entanglement, contribute to microplastic pollution, and degrade sensitive shoreline habitats. According to statewide environmental assessments, coastal litter is a persistent contributor to water quality impairment, particularly in heavily used recreational areas. This project aims to combat this issue in Hull.

Local residents care deeply about their town and regularly express concern about the state of public spaces. Informal cleanup efforts occur, but these are inconsistent and lack coordination, resources, and long-term planning. Without a structured program, litter reaccumulates quickly, and opportunities for education and prevention are missed. The absence of targeted waste

infrastructure and signage further exacerbates the problem, particularly for visitors unfamiliar with local disposal norms.

The urgency of this issue is increasing. I myself have worked in Hull for many years and have seen an extraordinary amount of litter along the areas where I walk to work. I know that the tight knit community of Hull would be very open to participating in the betterment of their town. Hull requires a proactive, organized response that combines cleanup with prevention and education.

Statement of Request

On behalf of S.O.S. Hull, this proposal respectfully requests **\$40,000** from the Massachusetts Environmental Trust to fund a one-year pilot of the Hull Waterfront Cleanup and Litter Prevention Initiative. The requested funds will support the planning and execution of a single, large-scale waterfront cleanup event, the purchase of durable cleanup and safety equipment, the installation of targeted waste and recycling infrastructure, and providing community support to promote positive long term change.

This initiative aligns directly with MET's funding priorities by protecting coastal and aquatic resources, improving local water quality, and engaging community members in hands-on environmental stewardship. While Hull is a small community, its environmental challenges reflect those faced by many Massachusetts coastal towns.

I think that this project fits well within the guidelines of the MET's upcoming grant which "invite proposals for projects that encompass Environmental Advocacy and Educational Activities Related to Aquatic Habitat Improvements and Threatened & Endangered Marine Life Protection & Conservation. Under these directives proposals should incorporate objectives that include enhancing biodiversity, promoting smart growth, understanding the impacts of climate change and fostering climate resilience strategies, promoting environmental awareness, and addressing Environmental Justice (EJ) concerns and communities" ([Massachusetts Environmental Trust](#)).

Rather than proposing an open-ended or recurring program, our proposal urges for a carefully designed single event whose outcomes can be concretely evaluated. The goal is to determine whether this initiative should be formalized as an annual community tradition in Hull. If the project is deemed successful and there is significant improvement to these issues, we would attempt to make it an annual project.

Description of Proposed Work

Project Objectives

The Hull Annual Waterfront Cleanup Pilot Initiative has five primary objectives:

1. First, the project aims to measurably reduce the volume of litter and debris along Hull's waterfront through a single, highly coordinated pilot cleanup event. This objective prioritizes visible, immediate environmental improvement in areas of greatest need.
2. Second, the initiative seeks to protect marine and coastal ecosystems by removing hazardous waste before it can enter the ocean or degrade shoreline habitats. By targeting tidal zones and high-traffic waterfront areas, the project addresses points where intervention is most effective.
3. Third, the project is designed to engage local residents and businesses in meaningful environmental stewardship. Volunteer participation is a vital part of this project as it is meant to uplift and enrich the lives of our local community.
4. Fourth, the initiative aims to educate residents and visitors about responsible coastal behavior, waste reduction, and the environmental consequences of marine litter. This serves to ensure that our efforts will be persistent even after our event. Includes putting up signs near high waste areas and signs for trash and recycling.
5. Finally, the project seeks to establish a replicable and scalable model for small-scale coastal cleanup initiatives. If successful, the pilot would provide a template that can be adapted for annual use in Hull or for implementation in other similar coastal communities.

Project Activities

***Volunteer Cleanup Event:** The project will organize one large-scale, well-publicized waterfront cleanup event to be held during the peak summer season, when litter accumulation is most severe and community engagement is highest. Volunteers will be recruited through S.O.S. Hull's existing networks, social media outreach, partnerships with local schools and civic groups, and coordination with town officials. The event will be carefully planned to cover priority areas—including beaches, seawalls, and public waterfront walkways—within a single day, ensuring visible impact and strong community momentum. The one-time pilot format is intentional: its success will be evaluated to determine feasibility for establishing the cleanup as an annual community tradition.

Equipment and Safety: Grant funds will be used to purchase reusable gloves, litter grabbers, safety vests, first aid supplies, and sorting materials. Large trash cans as well as other generic cleanup items will need to be purchased as well. These materials will be retained by S.O.S. Hull for future use should the event become annual, maximizing the long-term value of the initial investment and ensuring volunteer safety and efficiency. If the event does not become annual, the materials will be put to good use in other projects supported by S.O.S. Hull as well.

Litter Prevention Infrastructure: The project will install strategically placed trash and recycling units in high-traffic or severe litter areas. Clear signage will accompany these new units to encourage proper disposal and recycling.

Education and Outreach: Educational signage and printed materials will highlight the environmental impacts of marine litter and promote responsible behavior. Outreach will target both residents and seasonal visitors during the summer months, reinforcing Hull's commitment to coastal stewardship.

Community Partnerships: Local businesses will be invited to support the initiative through in-kind donations, sponsorship, or volunteer participation. Their involvement will strengthen community buy-in and enhance project sustainability.

Timeline

- **January–February:** Final planning, permitting, equipment purchasing, coordination with town officials
- **March–April:** Volunteer recruitment and outreach launch, involve local businesses
- **June or July:** One-day waterfront cleanup event
- **August–September:** Data analysis, community feedback collection
- **October:** Evaluation of pilot and decision-making regarding annual continuation

Measures of Project Success

The success of the Hull Annual Waterfront Cleanup Pilot Initiative will be evaluated through a combination of quantitative data collection and qualitative assessment. These measures are intentionally designed not only to document the immediate impact of the cleanup event, but also to inform a clear, evidence-based decision about whether the initiative should be continued as an annual program.

Quantitative evaluation will focus first on the physical outcomes of the cleanup itself. Volunteers will record the volume and estimated weight of litter collected, categorized by material type where possible: e.g., plastics, glass, metal, and fishing-related debris. This data will provide a decent measure of environmental remediation and will help identify the most persistent sources of waste along Hull's waterfront.

Participation metrics will also be tracked, including the number of volunteers, the diversity of participating groups (residents, students, local businesses), and overall turnout relative to outreach efforts early in the project. High participation will be treated as an indicator of community investment and the project's potential sustainability as an annual event.

Qualitative measures will complement these data points. Feedback will be solicited from volunteers, nearby residents, and participating businesses through brief surveys and informal debriefs. This feedback will assess perceptions of organization, impact, and community value, as well as suggestions for improvement. Particular attention will be paid to whether participants express interest in continued or annual involvement.

Additionally, project leaders should conduct observational assessments of sites of high importance in the weeks following the cleanup to evaluate short-term effectiveness of installed waste and recycling infrastructure. While long-term environmental change cannot be fully measured within a single pilot year, these observations will help determine whether the intervention meaningfully disrupts existing litter patterns.

In summary,

- Volume and weight of litter collected during cleanup events
- Number of volunteers participating
- Observed reduction in litter accumulation in targeted areas
- Community feedback from volunteers, residents, and local businesses
- Effectiveness of installed infrastructure, assessed through monitoring and observation

These metrics will be documented and summarized in a final report to MET. This report will explicitly address whether benchmarks for success were met and will outline a recommendation regarding the establishment of the effort as an annual community event.

Description of Available Facilities

Hull's public beaches, waterfront walkways, and open spaces will serve as the primary project sites. S.O.S. Hull will utilize existing community meeting spaces for volunteer coordination and storage of equipment. No new construction is required, keeping overhead costs low. A day should be set aside early in the production of this event to travel around Hull and determine first-hand which sites might need focusing.

S.O.S. Hull will utilize existing community facilities for project coordination, including public meeting rooms and shared community spaces for volunteer briefings, equipment distribution, and post-event debriefing. The group has meetings at the Hull City Hall frequently, and would be a good start to benign outreach. Cleanup equipment and materials will be stored temporarily in available municipal or partner-provided storage spaces, minimizing costs and logistical complexity. No new construction or permanent facilities are required for this project. This reliance on existing infrastructure ensures that the majority of grant funds are directed toward direct positive environmental impact.

In addition to public facilities, the project will draw on partnerships with local businesses to support on-the-ground logistics and volunteer engagement. Waterfront and town-center businesses, such as Jake's Seafoods, play an important role in Hull's daily life and have a direct stake in the cleanliness and appeal of the surrounding environment. These businesses are well positioned to support the cleanup effort by participating in volunteer teams and by providing contributions that enhance the volunteer experience, such as meals on the day of the event or food vouchers redeemable after participation. Such contributions reduce project costs while strengthening ties between environmental stewardship and the local economy.

Involving local businesses in this way serves both practical and symbolic functions. Providing meals or vouchers acknowledges the time and labor contributed by volunteers, helping sustain participation and morale during a physically demanding event. At the same time, visible business involvement reinforces the idea that waterfront preservation is a shared community responsibility rather than the burden of a single organization. By integrating businesses into the volunteer and support structure, the project increases its visibility and overall legitimacy by working directly with pillars of the community.

Qualifications of Personnel

S.O.S. Hull is a volunteer-based organization with experience in land-use advocacy, community engagement, and environmental planning. Project coordination will be led by Richard Bertone, in collaboration with S.O.S. Hull leadership and volunteers. The organization's established reputation and local knowledge position it well to manage this initiative effectively. The group also has valuable personal experience of living in the town that would allow us to allocate our resources to most effectively serve the town. Since this project is volunteer-based, staff from the S.O.S. Hull group would be leading groups of volunteers to conduct shoreline cleanup activities, oversee equipment use, and ensure that safety and organizational protocols are followed throughout the event. These leaders are familiar with Hull's land and community, allowing volunteer efforts to be directed where they will have the greatest impact. Their role will also include coordinating with town officials and community partners on the day of the event, as well as assisting with post-event evaluation and reporting.

Budget

Total Requested: \$40,000

- Cleanup and safety equipment: **\$12,500**
- Waste and recycling infrastructure: **\$15,000**
- Educational materials and signage: **\$4,000**
- Volunteer coordination and outreach: **\$2,500**
- Contingency and evaluation costs: **\$6,000**

Summary and Conclusion

The Hull Annual Waterfront Cleanup Pilot Initiative responds to a clear and escalating environmental need with an achievable community-driven solution. Hull's waterfront is central to the town's identity and community, yet it faces continuous pressure from litter accumulation driven by seasonal tourism, and somewhat limited waste infrastructure. If left unaddressed, this problem threatens both local ecosystems and shared regional waters.

By funding a single, well-planned pilot event, the Massachusetts Environmental Trust would enable immediate environmental remediation while also implementing long lasting change with the addition of signs and revamped trash and recycling units across town. The initiative pairs hands-on cleanup with education and prevention, emphasizing a lasting change.

Equally important, is the involvement of Hull's community. Volunteer engagement, partnerships with local businesses, and visible public outcomes are central to the initiative's design. These elements increase the likelihood that the cleanup will evolve into an annual tradition sustained by both local support as well as outside funding.

With support from the Massachusetts Environmental Trust, the Hull Annual Waterfront Cleanup Pilot Initiative will produce measurable environmental benefits, strengthen community stewardship, and generate a replicable model for other small coastal towns facing similar challenges. In conclusion, funding this project represents an investment not only in Hull's shoreline, but also in a scalable approach to protecting Massachusetts' coastal and aquatic resources.

End Matter

Cover Photo

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